
Playful Ambiguity and Political Authority in the Large Relief at Māmallapuram

Author(s): Padma Kaimal

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PLAYFUL AMBIGUITY AND POLITICAL AUTHORITY IN THE LARGE RELIEF AT MĀMALLAPURAM

BY PADMA KAIMAL

ART HISTORIANS HAVE DEBATED FOR DECADES THE meaning of scenes carved during the Pallava period into a cliff at Māmallapuram in southern India (fig. 1). Depicted on a sheer granite face are more than a hundred figures, each well over life-size and chiseled in a high relief that catches the bright coastal sunshine (fig. 2). Do these figures, carved during the seventh century, allude to penance the warrior Arjuna undertakes in order to gain a supreme weapon¹ or to the mythical king Bhagīratha's successful efforts to bring the celestial river Gaṅgā (Ganges) to earth?² Posed as exclusive alternatives, neither argument has won universal acceptance. Both stories correlate with many of the figures on this rock, and yet elements of the composition resist each narrative with equal stubbornness.

My purpose in this article is to pursue the suggestion advanced briefly by Michael Lockwood and Susan Huntington: that the relief means to tell both of these stories.³ I believe that, along with these two narratives, audiences were meant to perceive in this frieze a collection of metaphors, comic allusions, and political promises and that these multiple elements do more than coexist peacefully. They interact, as voices in a dialogue, working in cooperation rather than competition. Establishing these separate voices and facilitating their interaction is a series of purposefully constructed ambiguities, deliberate exploitations of the multiple connotations embedded within a single, fixed arrangement of carved figures. There is, furthermore, a playful quality to these ambiguities. The witty interplay among these voices sets up a deciphering game for viewers. Some narrative elements are openly comic.

Thus, I am arguing that Mikhail Bakhtin's ideas about dialogue, voicing, and humor have direct relevance to this piece of early Indian sculpture, despite the many kinds of distance that separate this relief from the European literature Bakhtin discusses.⁴ Patterns of interactive and deliberate ambiguity emerge, furthermore, in studies conducted by a number of scholars in a wide variety of disciplines. Māmallapuram does not represent

an isolated non-European example of these modes of expression.⁵

It is in the deliberate nature of these ambiguities that I find my colleagues' political readings of the Māmallapuram relief to make the most sense.⁶ Many of the themes articulated in this relief converge upon a set of ideas about kingship. This political meaning emerges with particular clarity where separate visual narratives overlap, as they do around the theme of royal protection. In tones that are alternately heroic and humorous, threatening and comforting, they articulate the Pallava king's promise to protect his people and the land they inhabit from all dangers—human, climatic, and divine. The dialogue communicating this message involves the voices of a second relief adjacent to the large relief in figure 2, as well as the voices within the Descent/Penance relief itself.

These voices convey their message all the more powerfully for having been temporarily perceived as separate. Each narrative can read as the description of yet another aspect of the king's protective capabilities. The initial confusion produced by the apparently competing meanings is, I maintain, a constructive and intended phase of reading this relief. Competition between alternative narratives eludes a quick reading. Uncertainty can make viewers pause, look beyond initial impressions, and appreciate the cleverness of this visual game. Lengthy contemplation can alert viewers to the complexity of messages conveyed; it can divert them with amusing subplots; it can also reveal convergence among these apparently contradictory meanings.

Who was intended to receive such messages? Another purpose of this article is to analyze the composition of audiences that congregated in front of this relief during the Pallava period and to imagine the processes through which viewers might have absorbed its ideas. I will come to this task at the end of this study, after delineating various narrative voices of this piece and the interactions among them. But first I must describe several physical aspects of this sculpture that suggest clues about the audiences at whom

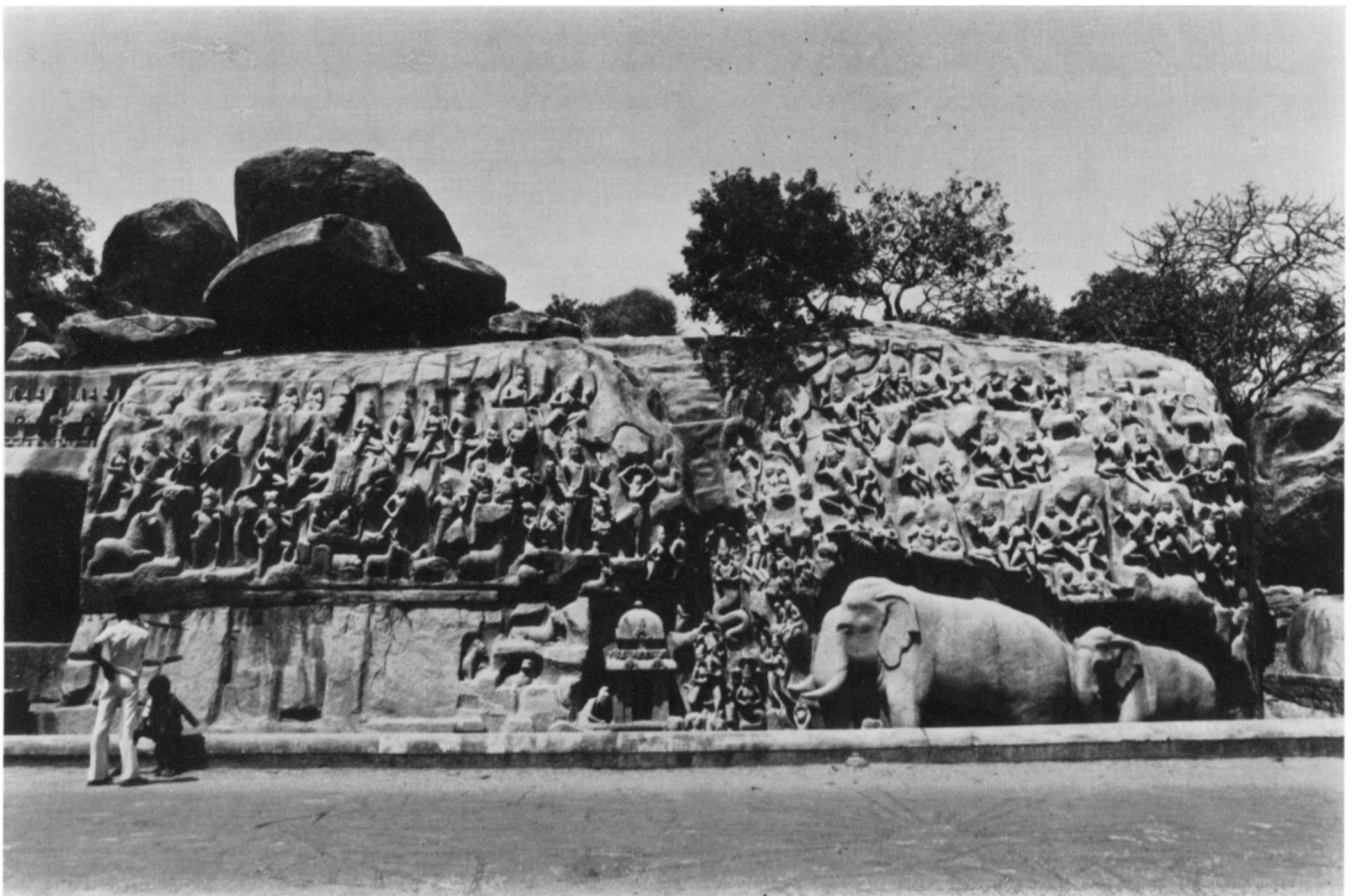
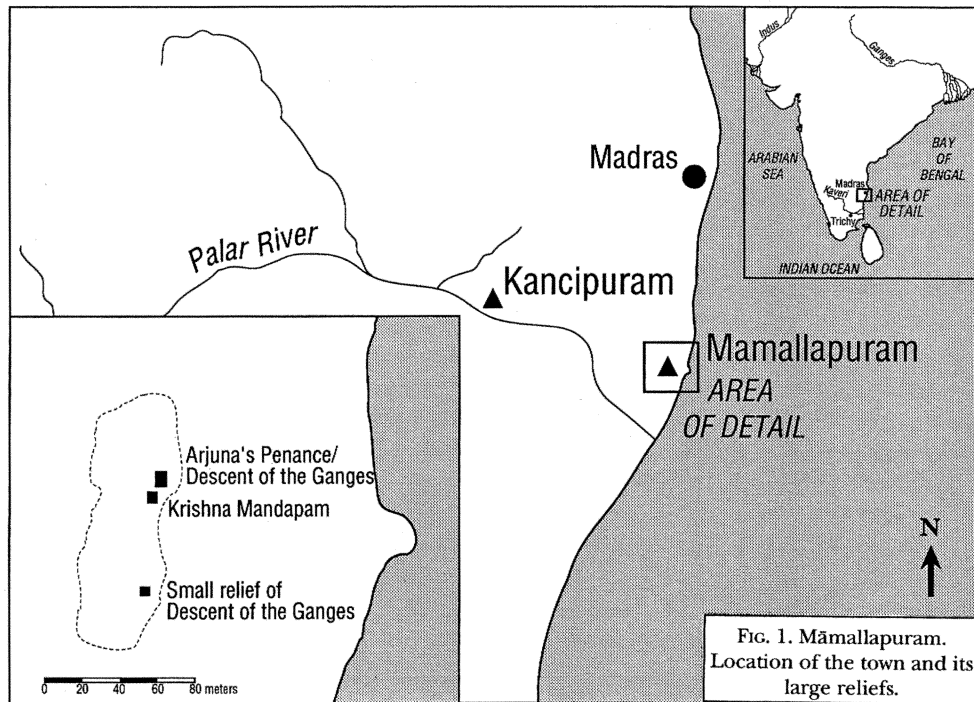


FIG. 2. Large relief of Arjuna's Penance and the Descent of the Ganges. Māmallapuram.

the relief was initially directed. These material realities have encouraged, in both the seventh century and the present, just such a process of protracted viewing as I have sketched above.

The relief overlooks the Bay of Bengal. While none of the area's many other rock outcroppings obstructs its view of the ocean, time has necessarily transformed the experience of viewing this work: more recent buildings and vegetation now interfere with the view from the east.⁷ Currently, most visitors arrive here by tour bus along the highway that extends north to Madras, and Māmallapuram (also called "Mahābalipuram") is now a small, remote fishing village. Originally, however, the huge carving must have been one of the first sights to greet the crowds that arrived by sea at what was once a teeming port. Since the Pallava dynasty was heavily engaged in maritime warfare and trade, and since Māmallapuram was its primary port, these crowds were probably sizeable. During the Pallava period great quantities of Māmallapuram's copious granite were carved into cave temples, free-standing monoliths, structural temples, and reliefs, and many of these monuments were inscribed by the Pallava kings themselves. The intense concentration of sculpture in this town suggests that the Pallavas recognized the opportunity offered here for addressing a substantial audience. I suspect that the prominent relief at the town's center made a particularly eloquent statement in this visual introduction to the Pallava kingdom.

Viewers drawn to this relief by its address to the sea and its monumental scale are then urged to study the composition at some length, moving to the left and right repeatedly and perhaps interacting with other members of the large crowds that probably assembled before this broad frieze. A deep pit in front of the relief establishes a distance of some ten meters between audience and carved surface, delaying a bit longer the viewer's recognition of figures presented. The great quantity of figures represented and the complexity of their interactions further encourage deliberate observation. Figures that wrap around the edges of the cliff and nestle in its central crevice also invite viewers to traverse this cliff's wide face. The figures accommodate both the moving viewer and the large crowds of spectators by projecting prominently and at a consistent angle from the rock surface. Figural proportions are not distorted, that is, in order to privilege a single viewing angle.⁸ This establishes a shifting

perspective that resolves coherently from any point across this facade, in contrast to a one- or two-point perspective, which would restrict observers to a single ideal vantage point.

The methods of narration employed here further detain the viewer. Rather than reading from left to right as Indian written languages do, or in a clockwise direction as the sculptural programs on Hindu temples often do, each narrative in this work demands to be traced by a gaze that hops about, linking distant figures, zigzagging up, down, left, right, and back again.⁹ With the recognition of additional readings, the mind revisits each figure, perhaps in a slightly different sequence, rethinking its significance and relationship to surrounding figures. Each time these paths are retraced, they become more familiar, more intimately within the viewer's possession. Like a verbal epic, this relief offers rewards of increasing intensity with each of the many rereadings it demands.

Arjuna's Penance/Descent of the Ganges

To assist modern readers in reconstructing this process of reading, I will summarize the two narratives most often perceived in this relief by modern scholars and the arguments for and against each interpretation. One of the most prominent of the narratives embedded here, Arjuna's Penance, is related in the *Mahābhārata* and in a poem (*mahākāvya*) reputedly popular at the Pallava court, the *Kīratārjunīyam* by Bhāravi.

The *Mahābhārata* describes Arjuna and his brothers, deprived of their kingdom by their cousins, retreating to the forest and preparing to win back what they had lost. Armed with a magic spell (*mātra*) that would compel the gods to grant his wishes, Arjuna headed north, settled in the wilderness where he practiced severe austerities, and succeeded in capturing Śiva's attention. Śiva appeared to him but in the guise of a hunter claiming to have shot the same boar Arjuna's arrow had just brought down. The hunters fought. When Arjuna recognized his opponent's identity, he stopped fighting and offered obeisance to the god. Śiva then granted Arjuna the weapon he had been seeking, the *paśupatāstra*, which was strong enough to destroy the world.¹⁰

Scholars who would see this narrative in the Māmallapuram relief read the penitent Arjuna in the emaciated, bearded man just to the left of the

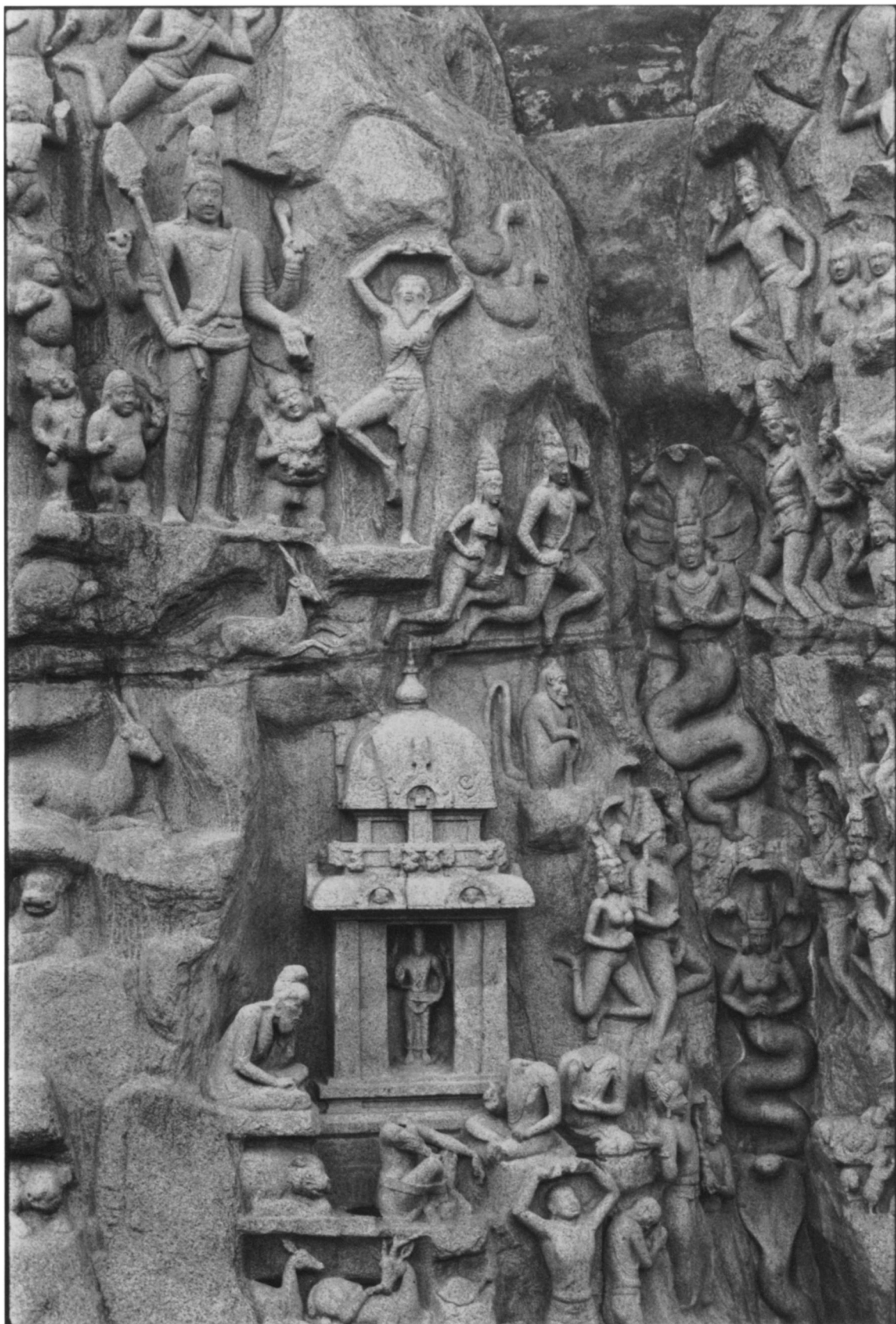


FIG. 3. Śiva, ascetic, and *nāgas*. Detail of cleft in large relief, Māmallapuram.



FIG. 4. Hunters and animals. Detail from left half of large relief, Māmallapuram.

vertical cleft that bisects the rock (fig. 3). His protruding ribs and untrimmed hair reveal that, in true ascetic fashion, he has abandoned care of his physical body. In the posture of the Penance of Five Fires, he stands on one leg, his hands joined together over his head, his face raised toward his hands and staring at the sun. (Four other fires are to be understood burning on the ground around him.) To his left stands a four-armed and colossal figure that may be read as Śiva granting Arjuna the *paśupatāstra*.¹¹ Wielding his famous trident in his lower right hand, Śiva extends his lower left hand toward the emaciated man, palm open and fingers extended downward in a gesture of bestowal (*varada mudrā*).¹² Directly beneath that hand stands a dwarf, his round belly ruptured into a leering demonic face. Is this a personification of the *paśupatāstra* that iconography texts describe as a terrifying aspect of Śiva?¹³ Five other fat dwarves of the sort that frequently accompany Śiva cluster behind the god.

The wilderness, appropriately, surrounds this scene of penitence. Lions, elephants, a lizard, and birds cluster amid trees and caves in the relief's lower registers (fig. 2). One of these animals is a boar (fig. 4). Near the animals on the left half of the cliff are male figures that represent hunters, distinguished by their mustaches, short kilts, and the bows they carry. Serpentine creatures (*nāgas*) undulate in the central crevice of the composition, their multiple cobra heads fanning out behind human heads and upper bodies (fig. 3). Frequently described as water spirits in Hindu mythology, these *nāgas* suggest here the presence of water in the vertical cleft beside Arjuna, perhaps a river beside Arjuna's camp.

Several disjunctions exist, however, between this relief and verbal narratives of Arjuna's Penance. For one thing, the boar who would lie pierced by two fatal arrows as Śiva grants Arjuna's boon spryly twists its neck and lifts a delicate foreleg (fig. 4). Though this boar matters to Arjuna's story more than the other wild creatures surrounding it, it receives no particular sculptural emphasis. Moreover, the hunters arranged across the left half of the cliff are difficult to peg as Arjuna or Śiva. There are four of them rather than two, and all four ignore the boar. They do not fight or, for that matter, interact with one another at all. Figures in the relief that might be components of Arjuna's story—hunters, the boar, Śiva, and the ascetic—are dispersed among other animals and a host of flying beings who have no obvious connection to that narrative. The ascetic's pose also seems not to fit this story. Why is he still performing penance when Śiva grants the boon? Once Śiva appears in his divine form, wouldn't Arjuna be bowing in adoration?¹⁴

Yet those who designed this relief may not have held the rigid and linear sense of time embedded in such objections. The designers¹⁵ may have intentionally collapsed a diachronic sequence (first Arjuna's asceticism, then Śiva after the fight) into a single scene, framing that within yet another moment (the boar and hunters before any arrows are shot).¹⁶ Nevertheless, this process of chronological manipulation does not account for the curious and, I think, deliberate omission of features that could articulate this narrative more precisely. At the Kailāsanāth temple in Kāñcīpuram, for example, Arjuna's Penance is clearly identified through the depiction of the



FIG. 5. Arjuna and Śiva battle over the boar.
Kailāsanāth temple, Kāñcīpuram.



FIG. 6. Celestials and animals ignoring the ascetic. Detail
from left half of large relief, Māmallapuram.

fight itself (fig. 5).¹⁷ The bodies of Śiva, clearly identified by his tall crown, and Arjuna, wearing the crossed chest straps of the archer, cross over each other in a bold “X” of energetic conflict. Bracing to deliver and receive blows, reaching for arrows, bows, and staves, the two figures take up mirroring poses as they act out their excruciatingly protracted and well-balanced duel. Just behind Śiva’s bent leg, a single boar may help identify this scene (although it seems, curiously, to be alive here too).

By contrast, the large relief at Māmallapuram avoids the finality that would exclude other interpretations of the same figures. The large relief merely contains Arjuna’s Penance as a possible subject. Scenes that indicate Arjuna’s Penance without ambiguity seem conspicuously absent from the large Māmallapuram relief. The emphasis this composition places on the idea of water presents a further obstacle to reading the relief simply as Arjuna’s Penance. Since the interaction between Arjuna and Śiva is the climactic event of that narrative, that scene should compel the

attention of figures as they look, gesture, and move toward the center of this relief. However, two celestial couples, two geese, and a monkey pointedly ignore Śiva and Arjuna to gaze at the watery cleft (figs. 3 and 6), an element that has little significance beyond scene-setting for that story.¹⁸ Thus, a river that is only incidental to Arjuna’s story eclipses the warrior as the focus of this composition.

Clearly, Arjuna’s Penance cannot account for the entire design of this relief, and yet the work communicates this resistance so quietly. The figures ignoring Arjuna are tucked well into the cleft, where they might initially escape notice, and the juxtaposition of penance group and cleft leaves viewers uncertain, at least for a moment, of the frieze’s true focus. This is a moment of very productive uncertainty, a moment during which images tug in several directions at once and viewers have the opportunity to glimpse the rich complexity such ambiguities can offer.

Something else has been encoded here as well, but that too has been done with a very light,

almost slippery, touch. The emphasis on water, the strongest indication of the presence of another narrative, suits nicely the story of the Descent of the Ganges. That story, a subplot in both the *Rāmāyaṇa* and the *Mahābhārata*, describes the terrible drought caused after the sage Agastya swallowed all the water of the earth.

For centuries the land had been barren and the ashes of the deceased, including those of King Bhagīratha's ancestors, lay unsanctified. Finally Bhagīratha performed penances in order to win the gods' assistance. Impressed by the king's austerities, the celestial river Gaṅgā agreed to descend to earth, but she warned that if she fell from such a height she would reach the earth in a murderous torrent. Śiva again intervened, catching the falling river in a lock of his matted hair where she wandered for years until the energy of her fall was spent. She trickled out gently, purifying and fructifying the earth. The multitudes of creation witnessed and celebrated her descent.¹⁹

Here is a story about divine water falling from the sky, an idea dramatically expressed by the precipitous angle of the cleft, by the devout gestures (*añjali mudrā*) of the *nāgas* in that cleft, and perhaps on festival days by a cascade of actual water over that cleft.²⁰ This water could then have pooled in the wide pit in front of the relief, lapping at the feet of the humans and elephants carved in the lowest register. Ascetics beside the base of the cleft take up the postures of prayer one still observes among bathers entering the Ganges River at Vārāṇasī, and the smiling elephants and their cavorting babies appear to rejoice in the glorious wetness at their feet (fig. 7).



FIG. 7. Elephant and her babies.
Detail from right half of large relief, Māmallapuram.

Penance in Gaṅgā's story is only a prelude to the fall of waters, which could explain why the cleft rather than the ascetic draws the attention of almost every figure in the composition. This rich variety of beings united by their focus upon the cleft could represent the entirety of creation witnessing and celebrating the momentous event. Assembled together are minor divinities, human beings, and animals. In the upper registers of the composition are celestial couples (male *gandharvas* and female *apsarās*) who look human but for the way they lift their feet behind them, a device suggesting that they float through the air (fig. 8). Interspersed among these couples are pairs of *kinnaras*, minor divinities who possess the lower bodies of birds and the upper bodies of humans. Hunters and the holy men (*ṛṣis*)



FIG. 8. Celestial couples and *kinnaras*. Detail from right half of large relief, Māmallapuram.

beneath the ascetic allude to the human sphere of creation (fig. 3). Sharing the earthly realm with them are all manner of animals, among them lions, elephants, monkeys, lizards, turtles, deer, antelope, geese, mice, and a cat.²¹

The ascetic can easily be read as Bhagīratha performing his penance and gaining his boon from Śiva. His juxtaposition with the cleft articulates the causal link between virtuous penance and the purifying cascade. Placed between Śiva and the cleft, his image links the visual representations of the boon won (falling water) and the boon realized (Śiva in *varada mudrā*), just as Bhagīratha’s action linked Gaṇḡā to Śiva physically by causing her to fall through the god’s hair.

Directly beneath this ascetic stands a small Viṣṇu temple surrounded by *ṛṣis* in prayer. The figure seated to the left of that shrine could also represent Bhagīratha, here thanking Viṣṇu, who in his form as the sage Kapila helped to convince Śiva to break Gaṇḡā’s fall.²² That several of the other men turn their backs upon the cleft as they pray to Viṣṇu suggests that this ashram scene is chronologically separate from the moment of Gaṇḡā’s Descent.

Beyond the imagery of the relief itself, external circumstances suggest that the Pallavas found the Descent of the Ganges a theme directly relevant to themselves. Gaṇḡā’s Descent appears on at least eleven other Pallava monuments, sometimes with the same arrangement of Śiva and the ascetic.²³ Pallava inscriptions liken Pallava kings to Gaṇḡā, claiming that these kings similarly purified the earth by their presence.²⁴

Other elements of this frieze, however, resist



FIG. 9. Śiva Gaṇḡādhara. Kailāsanāth temple, Kāñcīpuram.

the Gaṇḡā narrative. The prominent hunters and Śiva’s gesture differ from that in other Pallava representations of Gaṇḡā’s Descent. At Māmalla-puram he does not hold out the lock of hair that will interrupt Gaṇḡā’s torrential descent, nor



FIG. 10. Śiva Gaṇḡādhara. Lalitāñikura’s cave temple, Trichy.

does he bend one leg to brace himself against the force of her fall; he does both in shrine no. 24 of the Kailāsanāth temple in Kāñcīpuram (fig. 9) and at Trichy (fig. 10). In these and other Pallava representations of Gaṅgā's Descent there is also a tiny female personification of the river suspended just above Śiva's outstretched lock of hair, but the large Māmallapuram relief contains no such figure.²⁵

A Purposeful Multivalence

I would maintain that it is at this point—once the familiar and the puzzling narrative cues are recognized and sorted—that the viewer can discern the dialogue in which the multiple voices of this work engage. The complexity and the purpose of that interaction, which initially may sound quite discordant, begin to emerge as the viewer recognizes the deliberate quality of this narrative's ambiguity. By omitting the outstretched lock of hair, the personification of Gaṅgā, and fighting hunters, the designers of the Māmallapuram work have omitted iconography familiar to seventh-century viewers,²⁶ iconography that could have identified either narrative exclusively and thus restricted the reading of the relief. The absence of such unequivocal signs creates space for the coexistence and interaction of multiple voices and therefore meanings. Selecting instead the ascetic's penance and Śiva's acquiescence, features common to both stories, keeps that space open.²⁷ So do supporting figures that fit both narratives: the river could flow beside Arjuna's camp or down from the heavens; the animals and trees could describe Arjuna's wilderness or Bhagīratha's universe; the celestials could be celebrating the world's purification or sharing with all creation a vulnerability to Arjuna's weapon of universal destruction.²⁸

These ambiguities may even create room for further narrative voices. One scholar has viewed this relief as a depiction of *nāga* worship; others have read in it the story of Śiva as the beautiful mendicant (Śiva Bhikṣātaṇa), or a declaration of the supremacy of Lord Viṣṇu, or a Jain legend; yet others have understood it to identify this site as a sacred bathing place (*ārtham*).²⁹ While none of these readings has as yet been supported by sufficiently compelling evidence, and none accounts for nearly as many elements of the relief as Arjuna's Penance or the Descent of the Ganges do, the capacity of this relief to invite a wide

variety of interpretations seems significant in itself. The representations seem to possess a degree of neutrality that deliberately leaves them open to multiple readings. They are not infinitely open; boundaries do govern the limits of this piece's intelligibility. Penance, Śiva, and water are so visually assertive that any persuasive reading must involve them. But within such limits a flexibility is apparent, and that flexibility signals the strong possibility that this relief speaks in yet other narrative voices.

Comparisons between this relief and a smaller relief less than 200 meters to the south (see fig. 1) further suggest that the multivalence operating in the larger relief is purposeful.³⁰ The smaller relief appears to have been a source of inspiration for the larger cliff, where similar forms have been subtly altered and rearranged to absorb additional readings. The two reliefs are clearly variants on the same composition. The smaller relief depicts animals, heavenly beings, hunters, and *ṛṣis* turning toward a deep cleft that vertically bisects an east-facing granite hillside (figs. 11 and 12). Here too Śiva makes his boon-granting gesture to an ascetic who practices the Penance of Five Fires. Differences in style and iconography reveal that the smaller relief is the earlier of the two and that its iconography seems less multi-voiced: Arjuna's Penance is not at all evident here. Perhaps the designers' realization of potential in that composition for added voices motivated them to leave the earlier project unfinished.

A rather steady stylistic transformation from shallowly incised limbs, flatly arranged, to more three-dimensional and relaxed forms is discernible among the sculptures on datable Pallava monuments,³¹ and figures in the smaller relief resemble the former end of that spectrum. They emerge only tentatively from the rock surface (compare figs. 3 and 12), striking poses almost as angular as figures of the early seventh century.³² Elbows and wrists bend back upon themselves as if pressed behind a pane of glass.³³ The suppressed energy of these limbs works in dynamic tension with the static quality in the upright torsos, frontally presented. By contrast, figures in the larger relief give the illusion of breaking free from the rock wall. Their rounded limbs and fluid silhouettes recall later carvings patronized by Māmalla (r. 630–68) and Parameśvara (r. 672–700).³⁴ Set in three-quarter profile, these celestial couples project assertively into the space around them. The smooth diagonals articulated by their



FIG. 11. Left half of the smaller relief of the Descent of the Ganges, Māmallapuram.

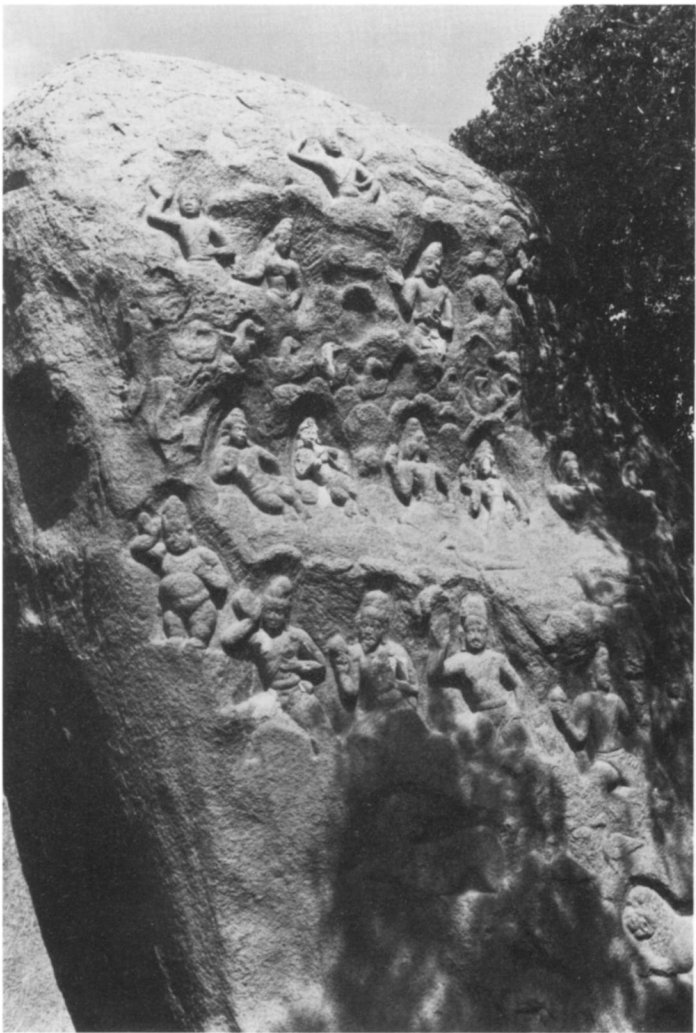


FIG. 12. Right half of the smaller relief of the Descent of the Ganges, Māmallapuram.

bodies convey an impression of graceful, easy motion.

Stylistic contrasts between these two reliefs stand out with special clarity in static figures. In the smaller relief, Śiva's flattened limbs adhere so closely to the surface of the rock that bright sunlight almost obliterates them (fig. 13). The rock's convexity intersects with the arch of his tensely jointed form, lending a special breadth to the shallowly incised thighs. In the larger relief, deep shadows imply the freedom of Śiva's torso from the rock and articulate the bold parallel forms of his columnar legs. The arch of his lower

back gives the appearance that Śiva has pulled free from the stone matrix, lending his pose an elasticity and majestic calm.

Iconographic differences between these two reliefs occur in precisely those features central to the interpretative debate: the numbers, locations, and interactions of boars and hunters; the compositional relationship between the penance group and the cleft; and Śiva's pose. The smaller relief contains no intimations of boar-shooting or hunters arguing. Two boars, both very much alive, mingle with lions and elephants (fig. 14). Three hunters already laden with spoils of the

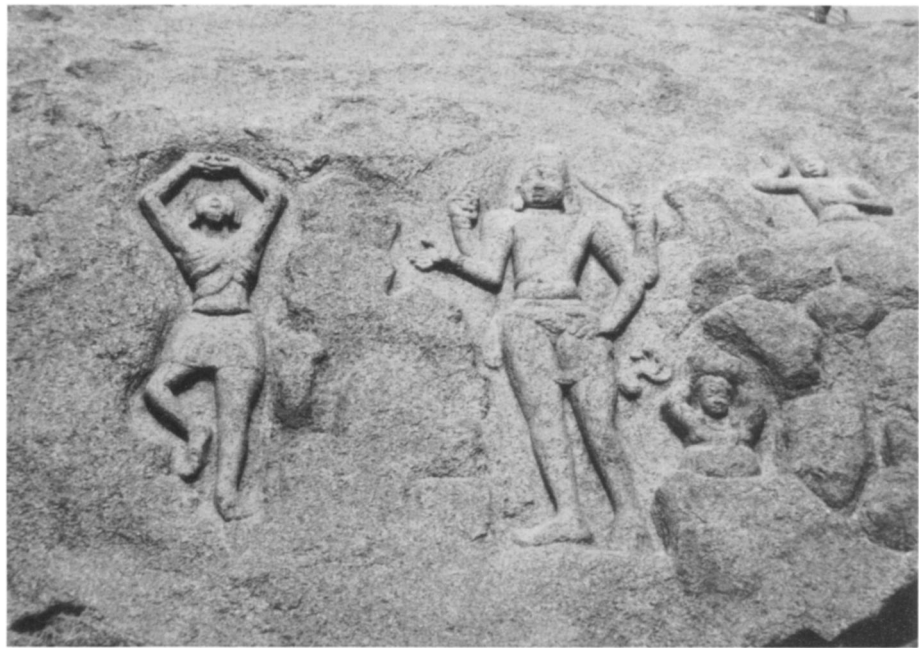


FIG. 13. Śiva and Bhagīratha. Detail from left half of the smaller relief of the Descent of the Ganges, Māmallapuram.



FIG. 14. Boars. Detail from left half of the smaller relief of the Descent of the Ganges, Māmallapuram.



FIG. 15. Hunters. Detail from left half of the smaller relief of the Descent of the Ganges, Māmallapuram.

hunt (two appear in fig. 15) move peacefully away from that cluster of animals. These hunters and almost every other creature carved on these boulders look toward the deep fissure at the center of the composition. Śiva and the ascetic do not stand near that fissure but are instead isolated on a separate stone facet at the upper left corner of the rock, so most of the figures in the left half of this relief turn their backs on the penance scene to address the cleft. Here there is no room to doubt that the cleft has primacy over Śiva and the penitent and that penance is a separate moment, merely a prelude to the climactic event in the fissure. Gaṅgā's fall rivets all eyes. To ensure this reading of the scene, the image of Śiva holds out a lock of his hair.

Certain new elements of the reworked version still emphasize the narrative of Gaṅgā's Descent. *Nāgas* have shifted from the upper reaches of the rock plane to the cleft itself; the cleft plunges down a steeper vertical, more effectively evoking a waterfall; the pit excavated in front of the cliff, and possibly a cistern above it, might have introduced the drama of real water. More substantial revisions, however, open up other levels of interpretation that the smaller relief cannot support. Shifting the ascetic and Śiva to a spot beside the cleft lends greater emphasis to the idea of penance, thus accommodating Arjuna's story. Both penance and the cleft now seem to draw the crowd's attention. Śiva holds an ax instead of a lock of his hair. Inverting the positions of Śiva and the ascetic enlarges upon this constructive confusion by adding Śiva to the list of beings who appear to direct themselves simultaneously to the

ascetic and the cleft. The larger relief reduces the number of boars to one and locates her closer to hunters. The introduction of the cat weaves another narrative into the web as it reemphasizes the centrality of penance.

Revisions that generated ambiguity probably received warm support from Pallava patrons, who seem to have appreciated the multivalence of visual and verbal signs as enthusiastically as they appreciated the themes of Arjuna's Penance and Gaṅgā's Descent. The Pallava court, located roughly 50 km inland at Kāñcīpuram (fig. 1), was a place of considerable literary sophistication: one of the kings was himself a playwright, and another king reputedly admired Bhāravi's *Kīratārjunīyam*.³⁵ The language of these works and of Pallava inscriptions is Sanskrit, a language rich in synonyms and one that lends itself well to punning and other multilayered verbal devices, for which it has its own term: *dhvāni*. The power of a Sanskrit term (or signifier) to encompass multiple and diverse meanings (to signify flexibly, that is) permitted authors to construct ornate parallels between quite separate entities. Writers took advantage of this, even constructing *double entendres* that ran the length of an entire book.³⁶

Pallava inscriptions take advantage of this capacity of Sanskrit, employing terms and titles that carry multiple meanings, dilating upon each of those meanings, and then pointing out intersections among them. One such inscription, mentioned above, parallels the Pallava kings and Gaṅgā as purifiers of the earth.³⁷ Other inscriptions use puns on royal names to identify the Pallava king, his wife, and son with the holy family

of Śiva, Umā, and Skanda.³⁸ In Trichy's Lalitānkura cave temple a poem flanking the image of Śiva Gaṅgādhara (fig. 10) creates synonymy between King Mahendra's claim to intimate possession of the Kāverī River and Śiva's relationship with the river goddess who dallied for eons in his hair. Part of this inscription reads:

Being afraid that the God who is fond of rivers [Śiva], having seen the Kāverī, whose waters please the eye, who wears a garland of gardens, and who possesses lovely qualities, might fall in love with her [also], the Daughter of the Mountain [Gaṅgā] has left her father's family to reside . . . permanently on this mountain, calling this river [Kāverī] the beloved [wife] of the Pallava [king].³⁹

This text expands upon the idea of rivers, establishing parallels between Gaṅgā and south India's Kāverī by introducing Kāverī with three encomia ("whose waters please the eye," etc.) that apply equally well to Gaṅgā. Here too a moment of productive confusion creates an opportunity for the receiver to appreciate the similarities between separate entities. Since Kāverī's beauty and the fecundity she lends the earth (i.e., she "wears a garland of lovely gardens") equate her with Gaṅgā, she becomes a rival for Śiva's subtly adulterous attentions. Gaṅgā in her jealousy then abandons her own mountain home for the rocky hilltop in Trichy, a conceit that points out the proximity to mountains that further likens these two rivers. When Gaṅgā acts on her jealousy, her admonition to Śiva exhibits yet another parallel, this time between Śiva and the Pallava king Mahendra. Through Mahendra's claim to possess exclusively a lovely river, that king asserts himself as the god's earthly analog.

While Michael Lockwood ultimately rejects the possibility that the Māmallapuram relief represents these two narratives simultaneously, he has proposed that Sanskrit's capacity for word play generally predisposed artists and viewers of the Pallava period to make and view art images on multiple levels.⁴⁰ Certainly, Pallava designers often paired these punning inscriptions with visual counterparts. The inscription quoted above frames the sculpted image of Śiva Gaṅgādhara in figure 10. Inscriptions equating the royal family with Śiva's family marked temples that housed representations of Śiva seated with Umā and Skanda (*Somaskanda*) in their inner sancta.⁴¹ It seems likely, then, that these visual counterparts embrace the multiple voices that their

accompanying inscriptions do. These representations of Śiva may have functioned as metonyms for the Pallava king, describing through divine metaphors the nature of the king's authority and responsibility.

Projecting Political Authority

I see this sort of political statement as one purpose of the erudite playfulness operating in the Descent/Penance relief. Puns can be eloquent indices of the surprising commonalities between their seemingly disparate layers of meaning, and in this case those layers intersect with some intensity at issues central to Pallava kingship. The narratives about Gaṅgā and Arjuna converge on the subject of penance, and in both cases penance leads to protection. In both stories, heroic leaders protect their families, their kingdoms, and the earth from threats of war, natural disaster, and divine wrath. Arjuna's act of penance makes him the supreme warrior, enabling him to defend his brothers and their shared kingdom against rival kings. Bhagīratha's act of penance establishes the ritual purity and fertility of his kingdom and of the entire earth as well. Self-sacrifice gives both men special access to the gods, access that they use to elicit from the gods items (such as weapons and water) that enable kings to guarantee the safety of their kingdom. Śiva too embodies the protective when he grants Arjuna the weapon that guarantees victory in the great war and when he averts natural disaster by catching Gaṅgā in his locks. Meanwhile, the adult elephants that dominate the right half of the composition shelter their playful babies under their powerful bodies.

These themes had considerable political resonance for kings of early south India. The paramount duty of kings was to protect their subjects from all manner of threats. Like Arjuna the king needed to be the best warrior in the land, and he enacted that role by waging almost constant battles against neighboring kings.⁴² The king's protective responsibilities extended beyond the human sphere. He was thought to link his kingdom to the rest of the cosmos and to maintain through the performance of special rituals the proper balance in the climate, the fertility of the fields, and the good will of the gods. Heroic in stature, the king was the conduit through which good things flowed from the rest of the cosmos to the people of his kingdom.⁴³

The coincidence between the narratives in this relief and the rhetoric of early south Indian kingship seems purposive and calculated. Indeed, the desire to expatiate upon the power of the king may have motivated designers to interpolate multiple narratives into the larger relief. The coexistence of Arjuna’s and Gaṅgā’s stories within the large relief articulates these ideas about kingship with special force. Points at which these narratives interact most energetically are the issues central to ideals of royal behavior. The possible identities of the ascetic characterize the Pallava leader as both king (Bhagīratha) and military hero (Arjuna). Divergences between the two narratives also enrich the royal promise: Bhagīratha offers his kingdom climatic and ritual protection; Arjuna’s story adds the dimension of military safeguard. Both stories demonstrate that beings in all levels of creation rely upon the heroic behavior of the king.

It is appropriate to listen for kings’ voices in these works because, for one thing, the Pallava kings are the most likely patrons of Māmallapuram’s carvings.⁴⁴ Furthermore, the nature of early Indian kingship permitted art to play a

significant role in promulgating royal authority, which depended heavily upon popular perceptions of a king’s heroism, potency, and strength, upon his ability to project charismatic images of himself that elicited the devotion of his subjects.⁴⁵ The visual arts provided an opportunity for presenting appealing, compelling reflections of himself to large audiences of potential subjects whose loyalty he wooed. Indeed, the Pallavas and other kings in early India patronized numerous art works depicting the feats of mythic heroes, and these may incorporate allegories demonstrating precisely the qualities the patrons claimed to possess.⁴⁶

Another hint of the political in the Descent/Penance relief is the presence of half a dozen heraldic male lions carved at the left and right edges of this composition (fig. 16).⁴⁷ The manner in which they are rendered suggests that they are royal emblems of the Pallavas, and their flanking placement suggests that issues raised by Gaṅgā’s Descent and Arjuna’s Penance lay within the sphere of the Pallava kingship. Whereas the other animals in this relief are softly carved in poses of gentle alertness, these lions snap to attention



FIG. 16. Heraldic lions at right edge of the large relief, Māmallapuram.

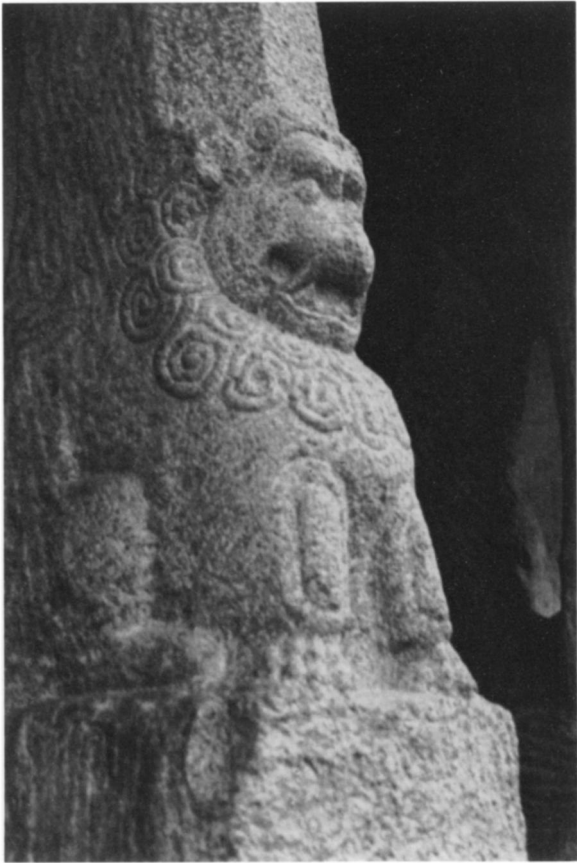


FIG. 17. Lion column. Dharmarāja Ratha, Māmallapuram.

with the stylized rigidity of a military guard. They take on postures almost identical to one another. Each lion strains his mouth open in the same wide snarl and arches his tail in an elegant loop. The exaggerated sinews of their legs stand out dramatically, a schematization of ferocity and power. Each mane is composed of a precise grid of tight curls. This energetic stylization lends the lions an emblematic quality that separates them from the narrative flow of the rest of the relief. Their resemblance to heraldic lions atop columns bearing inscriptions of the Emperor Aśoka's decrees may have lent these lions royal associations.⁴⁸ Such lions also had specifically Pallava connotations. They are rendered sedant on column bases or rampant along exterior walls in almost every structure excavated or constructed by the Pallavas after the early seventh century (see

for example fig. 17). At least two Pallava kings, Simhaviṣṇu and Rājasimha, used the term for lion, *siṃha*, in their coronation names. Rājasimha (Nandivārman II Pallava) drew heavily on leonine symbolism to present himself. His inscriptions characterize him as “the lion in battle . . . the lion among princes . . . he who resembles the lion in valor.” He also appears to have been responsible for excavating the fantastic cave in Śaluvankuppam that is rendered as a colossal lion’s open mouth.⁴⁹

A second relief panel further urges viewers to see in the large relief allusions to the king’s protective capabilities. Beyond the left or southern edge of the Descent/Penance relief, a long panel depicting Kṛṣṇa lifting Mount Govardhan (figs. 18 and 19) expresses this idea through the voice of another ancient myth.



FIG. 18. View from the left end of the Kṛṣṇa relief, Kṛṣṇa *maṇḍapa*, Māmallapuram.

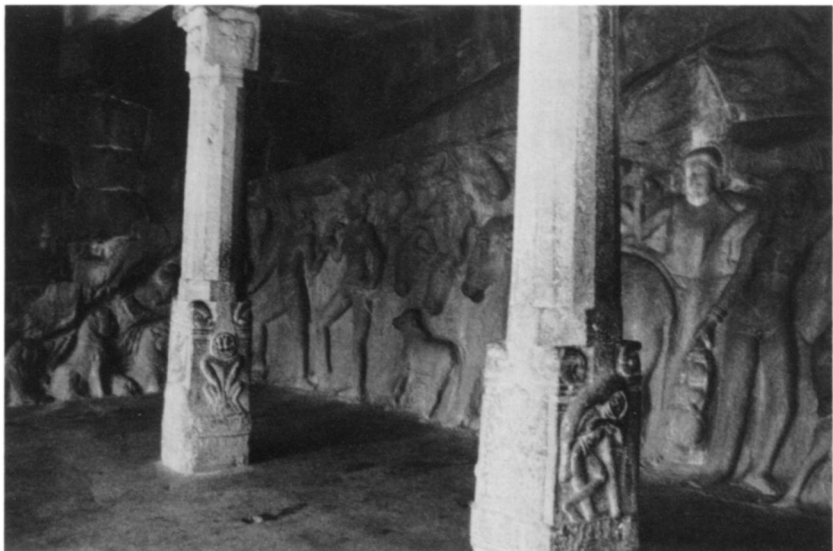


FIG. 19. Villagers and cows under Mt. Govardhan. Left half of the relief in the Kṛṣṇa *maṇḍapa*, Māmallapuram.



FIG. 20. Kṛṣṇa lifting Mt. Govardhan.
Detail from Kṛṣṇa *maṇḍapam*, Māmallapuram.



FIG. 21. Kṛṣṇa with his arm around a man.
Detail from Kṛṣṇa *maṇḍapam*, Māmallapuram.

The *Bhagavata Purāna* describes Kṛṣṇa, one of the most charismatic of Lord Viṣṇu’s earthly incarnations, lifting Mount Govardhan to shelter his village against Indra’s wrath. Insulted when Kṛṣṇa told the cowherds to stop worshipping Indra, the rain god sent a torrential storm to drown their village. Saying, “I shall . . . by

my own divine power protect [the village of] Vraja, which has sought shelter in Me, looks upon Me as its Protector, nay, which constitutes My own family!” Kṛṣṇa held up the mountain top as a sort of giant umbrella, and under it the entire community huddled in safety until the downpour ended.⁵⁰



FIG. 22. Cow licking her calf.
Detail from Kṛṣṇa *maṇḍapam*, Māmallapuram.



FIG. 23. Heraldic lions. Detail from left edge of Kṛṣṇa *maṇḍapam*, Māmallapuram.



FIG. 24. View toward the Kṛṣṇa *maṇḍapam*, past the large relief (right) of Arjuna's Penance and the Descent of the Ganges, Māmallapuram.

The scene depicted in Māmallapuram captures the sense of security conveyed by Kṛṣṇa's resolution of this crisis. Here too myth articulates a royal promise, and stylized lions frame a scene in which a leader heroically defends his followers. And once again this act of heroism involves the threat of climatic disaster, divine intervention, and great quantities of water. Babies and old men, young men, women, and cows cluster around Kṛṣṇa as his miraculous strength saves them all. He appears twice in this relief, once supporting the mountain, his body tall, erect, and columnar (fig. 20), and once curved protectively around an older man, perhaps his adoptive father Nanda (fig. 21). A cow solicitously licks her calf (fig. 22), paralleling Kṛṣṇa's enveloping posture and embodying his protective spirit. Lions with manes composed of regular curls watch this scene from either end of the frieze (fig. 23). The startlingly

human, mustachioed face on the second lion from the left seems to insist that we read these stylized creatures emblematically and that as emblems these lions and the scene they frame are indices to the world of human affairs.

Presentation as well as content links the Kṛṣṇa relief to the large relief of Arjuna's Penance and Gaṅgā's Descent. Although the Kṛṣṇa relief has been masked since the Vijayanāgara period by a pillared *maṇḍapa*, these compositions would originally have operated as a visual pair, forcing attention toward the ideas they share. The reliefs are contemporary in style. The figures of the Kṛṣṇa relief are of the same heroic scale, and they display the easy torsions and gentle modeling of figures in the large relief. The Kṛṣṇa relief stands just a short distance to the south of the large relief (see fig. 24), carved from the east face of the same granite hill. The Kṛṣṇa relief, squatter and set

deeper into the hill, may have read as a kind of subordinate clause, a secondary voice or echo of the themes in the larger relief.⁵¹

Pairing like punning can alert viewers or readers to convergent meanings.⁵² A new set of figures here rearticulates and thus reinforces ideas around which the multiple voices of the Descent/Penance relief converse. The three narratives and their symbols overlap at the same place. The heroic leader who possesses special access to divine power protects his community from yet another imminent disaster. Kṛṣṇa keeps company with Śiva, Bhagīratha, and Arjuna as yet another metonym for the king. If Arjuna's and Gaṇḡā's stories delineate a king who can protect his kingdom against climatic and human threats, the Kṛṣṇa narrative adds the promise of protection from the wrath of other gods. Again, the threatened cataclysm involves water as an uncontrolled force that must be mastered by the heroic leader.

Controlling water was a central feature of Pallava kingship, as the Trichy inscription suggests in its boast that Mahendra possessed the Kāverī River. The Pallavas would have derived enormous popular support from building reservoirs and the canal system that still remains in Māmallapuram.⁵³ In this monsoon climate where water must be carefully managed to permit cultivation during the ten dry months of the year, such public works meant the difference between survival and famine. Sponsoring these projects was one way in which kings could demonstrate their ability to guarantee the kingdom's fertility. Sexual innuendo in the Trichy inscription about Mahendra's relationship to the lovely Kāverī is another way of expressing this function of the king. The king was expected to guarantee the land's fecundity with the potency of his own body. Intercourse between him and the fecund river, who "wears lovely gardens," paints a vivid image of him doing just that.⁵⁴

While inscriptions and artistic style identify the king of the Trichy inscription as Mahendra I and the likely patron of the Descent/Penance relief as Māmalla or Parameśvara I, the messages of these reliefs were relevant well beyond the reigns of these individual kings. The notion of the king as a cosmic and terrestrial protector of kingdom, crops, family, and all living beings informed Pallava rhetoric for decades before and after Māmalla.⁵⁵ The large Māmallapuram relief expressed the collective aspirations of many individual rulers, lending the work an enduring power to signify. These images were capable of evoking

meaningful associations throughout the Pallava period, and perhaps beyond.

The unfinished state of the lower left side of the composition has led some to understand this relief as the product of a single king's patronage, abandoned because of successors' lack of interest in the work. Both the quantity of work done at Māmallapuram and the substantial shifts in style apparent there make the single-patron theory unlikely, however, and since almost every piece of sculpture at Māmallapuram remains unfinished to some degree, incompleteness at this site seems to reflect something other than the death of a patron and the indifference of his successors to his projects.⁵⁶ Death alone seems an insufficient explanation for kings having initiated dozens of projects and completed none of them. Nor, to my knowledge, does the large relief bear traces—apparent on other monuments in Māmallapuram—of later kings' hostility toward it.⁵⁷ Joanna Williams has demonstrated that in numerous contexts Indian sculptures have been regarded as fully adequate without being technically complete.⁵⁸ This relief may have been found to perform its intended functions satisfactorily without the addition of more forest scenes in the lower left corner.

The Parodic Element

A political reading of this relief emphasizes the majesty of its message and form, but regal grandeur is by no means an unanswered voice in this visual dialogue. Another voice demonstrates quite clearly the presence of the comic in this frieze. This voice speaks through the scene of the cat just to the right of the cleft's lowest point (fig. 25). The cat upon his hind legs and the adoring bevy of mice surrounding him recall the *Pañcatantra* story of a cat who lived beside the Ganges and preached brilliantly about his own enlightenment, abstinence, and mercy, only then to feast upon his credulous audience.⁵⁹ The cat in this sculpture, who stands right beside the riverine cleft, demonstrates this professed abstinence by striking up the Penance of Five Fires. Several plump mice gather at his feet; one gazes at the cat with special devotion, his front feet pressed together as if in *añjali mudrā*.⁶⁰

It is this cat that alerts us to the presence, and indeed the considerable significance, of humor in this relief. That he parodies the Arjuna/Bhagīratha figure is inescapable. His location and posture forge that link. Just opposite the cat, and



FIG. 25. Cat practicing the Penance of Five Fires.
Detail of large relief, Māmallapuram.

directly beneath Arjuna/Bhagīratha, a *ṛṣi* also gazes upward through interlaced fingers (fig. 3), visually linking these other two penitents. The cat's noticeable, protruding ribs establish his commonality with the human ascetics, but the paws that cannot quite reach each other signal the cat's true animal nature and thus his imminent bestial conduct. The cat parodies human behavior by translating the acts of heroes and kings into the base animal world, thus inverting the natural hierarchy. He also inverts his own feline nature temporarily by posing as a vegetarian. And he subverts expectations (the audience's and the mice's) of what holy renunciation produces.

What does this joke mean? Why is it here? The cat does introduce another instance of *dhvāni*, toying with the idea of penance that binds the other two narratives together. The cat subplot does nothing, moreover, to restrict the relief's ambiguous relationship to the narratives of Garīgā and Arjuna. The cat only reinforces an idea (penance) common to both larger stories, intimating yet again a deliberate quality to those ambiguities. Perhaps also the contrast established

between the cat's greedy calculation and noble self-sacrifice is meant to warn viewers against false leaders or, somewhat sardonically, to allude to the wide range of good things to be gained by penitent behavior.

More promising are the possibilities suggested by similar applications of parody, inversion, and travesties of the sacred that Bakhtin finds in the writings of Rabelais.⁶¹ Bakhtin understands these devices as the "language of the marketplace," forms of carnival, or "the culture of folk humor," which in medieval Europe helped to unify society by dissolving, at least periodically, the barriers of rank. The shared language of this humor, he argues, permitted genuine communication among disparate elements of society and thus a sense of commonality.⁶² Bakhtin also discerns in Rabelais's humor references to the intertwined significance of eating and death as interconnected phases of regeneration and decay.⁶³ Certainly, that interconnection informs the story of this cat too, as it informs widely held Hindu beliefs of the cyclic nature of existence. That association could function in this relief to unify other apparently disparate components of narrative, such as epic drama and feral farce.

And yet what evidence exists that these meanings and social processes operated in seventh-century south India? Perceptions of the comic are, of course, not static or continuous between cultures.⁶⁴ There is, furthermore, some disparity in the source of the voices I am comparing: Rabelais articulated the humor of the common people, who bore considerable hostility toward those of high rank, whereas the Descent/Penance seems in at least some of its voices to speak for the king. Rabelaisian humor threatens to undermine the royal implications of the entire relief. Does the presence of the cat's parody indicate that the Pallava kings were not, after all, authors of the relief's messages? The right half of this relief, with its devious feline and cheery elephants, may function in a kind of dialogue with the other half of the composition, providing a jovial counterpoint to grander events acted out at the left. Both sides, however, must tolerate to some degree a humorous reading if the messages of the work are not to be undercut by this satiric cat. Something of the jaunty note this cat strikes in its direct mimicry of the penitent who stands near Śiva suffuses the tone of the entire relief. If royal interests were somehow still served by imagery that mocked the authority of the king, what could those interests have been?

Again, however, I believe we are presented with

multiple voices that appear discordant only at first. Two plays, *The Bhāgavadajjuka* and *The Mattavilāsa*, indicate that the Pallava sense of the comic had much in common with the “folk humor” Bakhtin finds in the medieval European marketplace. These raunchy farces are peppered with Rabelaisian imagery of the body’s “lower stratum.” One of the central characters, a Śaivite holy man consumed by every carnal appetite, broadly satirizes contemporary religious traditions.⁶⁵ These plays have been attributed to the Pallava king Mahendra I. Far from seeing himself excluded from this mode of humor, or from seeing such humor as undermining royal style, then, the Pallava king may have perceived gluttony, decay, debauchery, parody, and inversion as rhetorical devices well suited to his own motives for writing. In fact, David Shulman finds that the comic (*vilaiyāḷal*) was, along with the tragic, one of the most important modes through which south Indian kingship expressed itself. In Tamil literature, he finds the comic expressed through “inversions,” “mirror effects,” and “transformative powers,” among other devices.⁶⁶ Might he have gone even farther in the visual arts, permitting parody of himself and his kingly duty? That possibility depends much, I think, on the composition of the audience.

Viewers of the Relief

Who would contemporary viewers of this relief have been, and would they have perceived the purposeful ambiguities, parodic humor, and royal aspirations that I read there? Would deliberately elusive iconography have enhanced the dialogic relationship of these voices for seventh-century viewers, keeping the process of reading open and permitting multiple allusions? I can deduce two modes through which contemporary audiences may have perceived the ambiguities of this work, one of interactions between individuals and one in which the multiple voices interacted within the thoughts of a single viewer. In the first or “externalized” mode, the diverse voices would each have addressed viewers separately, meeting them at their own preferred level of understanding and conducting them along one of several pathways toward common conclusions about kingship. The adamancy of the recent iconographic debate suggests that for modern viewers a single pathway can be very tempting: most scholars have perceived a

single story to the exclusion of other readings.

This model also corresponds to some aspects of the Pallava period’s viewing context. Each narrative may have addressed a different constituency among the eclectic crowds arriving at this port of entry. The Pallava kingdom’s considerable maritime contacts would have brought to Māmallapuram Southeast Asians who knew the *Rāmāyaṇa* well, Mediterranean merchants who might have been familiar with *Pañcatantra* tales through Aesop, and people from other parts of the Indian subcontinent who would have known the *Mahābhārata* as well as the *Rāmāyaṇa*. Multiple points of entry into this relief’s narrative content would have permitted culturally diverse viewers to feel themselves included in this introduction to the Pallava kingdom. Interaction among the various narrative options would have occurred if viewers were able to converse together, comparing and perhaps arguing about their divergent perspectives. The wide face of the cliff bearing these images would have permitted large crowds to assemble before it for such interaction. In this capacity, the sculptural ensemble may have worked to teach viewers to read on multiple levels.⁶⁷

The second or “internalized” mode would operate if an individual viewer were capable of perceiving multiple, interactive, and contradictory voices within this set of signs. The viewer who perceived in this relief Arjuna’s Penance as well as the Descent of the Ganges appreciated the king’s ability to protect his subjects from military as well as climatic threats. Extra voices gave the royal promise extra weight. The viewer who perceived the *Pañcatantra* reference appreciated the humor and whimsicality that is part of this interaction of voices. Engaged by this cleverness, the viewer may have been more receptive to the political message embedded here. The viewer who perceived connections between this relief and the adjacent Kṛṣṇa scenes may have felt comforted that humble villages of herders could expect the same protection granted to the powerful kingdoms of the Ganges plain.

The internalized mode relies on viewers who could read the ascetic figure simultaneously as Arjuna, Bhagīratha, and the king and who could also conversely see metonyms for the king in the figures of Śiva, Kṛṣṇa, and the ascetic. Such viewers would have shared with the designers of these reliefs an interest in the plurality of voices that speak through a given sign and enjoyed the interplay among those multiple voices. Sophisticated

games of this sort rely upon makers and viewers also sharing knowledge of the same body of myths and common visual languages for depicting them.

The monoculturalism of this discourse might appear to have addressed only those viewers already integrated into Pallava culture and thus to work against the dynamics of a port city. And yet the relief's address to the sea suggests designers who presumed that the culture defined by this discourse extended well beyond the geographic limits of the Pālār River basin. Indeed, many visitors may have had access to this internalized mode of reading because the stories in this relief had earned international recognition and because its interactions of multiple voices ask the mind to work in patterns so similar to those demanded by the word plays of Sanskrit, the *lingua franca* of India. The indirect and repetitive manner through which the Descent/Penance relief narrates also parallels closely a technique used in the widely known Sanskrit epics. Both the *Rāmāyaṇa* and the *Mahābhārata* clarify events in the main story line by interjecting numerous subplots that parallel, contrast with, and expand upon similar themes.

Given an audience of such diversity and yet with so many overlapping fields of knowledge, the humor of the marketplace to which Bakhtin ascribes great powers of social unification would have suited the Pallava agenda rather well. Māmallapuram's port may have been a Pallava-period equivalent to the marketplaces of medieval Europe: a place in which certain types of theatricality and humor were sanctioned and expected, a place for the interchange of ideas and rough treatment, a place where disparate groups mixed. Parody invited an eclectic crowd to share in the bond of communal laughter and thus encouraged a perception of social cohesion. Since the parody was based on literature familiar to a wide range of viewers, recognition of the familiar may have produced in viewers a sense of inclusion in the Pallava kingdom. Bakhtin points out that travesties upon the notions of the sacred only work for audiences that share a language of images, an audience "initiated in familiar intercourse."⁶⁸ As the Descent/Penance relief permits a large audience to view it together, viewers could have heard one another laugh and may thus have been made aware of their cultural commonality. These results may have been, to Pallava kings, worth the expense of self-travesty.

Modern audiences that arrive by tour bus have lost much of this viewing context, but they still stand in large groups before the Descent/Penance relief for protracted periods as if feeling themselves directly addressed; they still converse together about the images; and they still move left and right across the facade, taking in the richness and complexity of the composition. Although dogmatic tour guides tend to present only the case for reading Arjuna's Penance, these audiences still bring some familiarity with other narratives to their experience of the relief, and many of them speak languages that retain from Sanskrit a penchant for punning. The potential still exists for recognizing the encoded ambiguities. And these audiences still laugh if one among them finds the cat. Almost everyone derives joy from the smiling elephants. Humor, at some level, certainly persists.

Conclusion

The strenuous tone of my call for tolerating ambiguity may strike the reader as somewhat ironic, but my purpose in writing this article has not been to close debate about the Descent/Penance relief. Far from finding the persisting debate "disheartening,"⁶⁹ I hope others will continue to discover in this relief new voices interacting with those I have described above. It seems quite likely that a single intellect—even one trained to look for *dhvāni*—cannot exhaust the panoply of references already located in this relief. The relief's unfinished state invites us to consider that yet other voices may have been encoded. At the same time, I wish to stress that I do not see indecision as having permeated the process of *creating* this relief. I do not believe that the creators of this relief, the senders of these signs, were uncertain about what the relief could mean, nor do I suspect that these designers sought to bewilder viewers. I see the ambiguities as opportunities for communication among the work's many voices. In this case, that communication reveals an intramural coherence among the work's supposedly competing voices and links between this relief and representations in adjacent sculptures. These conclusions emerge only if the process of reading remains as open as possible and the separate voices of the work are permitted to reverberate and even conflict.

Notes

1. Among the proponents of this argument are T. N. Ramachandran, "The Kīratārjunīyam in Indian Art," *Journal of the Indian Society of Oriental Art* 28 (1951): 58–89; M. Hirsh, "Mahendravarman I Pallava: Artist and Patron of Māmallapuram," *Artibus Asiae* 48, 1/2 (1987): 109–30; S. Kramrisch, *The Art of India* (London: Phaidon Press, 1965), 205; and C. Sivaramamurti, *Gaṅgā* (New Delhi: Orient Longman, 1976), 79.
2. Among the strongest cases advanced for the Descent of the Ganges reading are: V. Goloubew, "La Falaise d'Arjuna de Mavalipuram et la Descent de la Gaṅgā sur la Terre, selon le Rāmāyaṇa et le Mahābhārata," *Journal Asiatique*, 2^e sér., 4 (Paris, 1914): 210–12; A. H. Longhurst, *Pallava Architecture*, pts. 1 and 2, *Memoirs of the Archaeological Survey of India* 17 (1924) and 33 (1928) (rpt. New Delhi: Cosmo Publications, 1982), 40–44; Michael Lockwood, Gift Siromoney, and P. Dayanandan, *Mahabalipuram Studies* (Madras: Christian Literature Society, 1974), 34–41; Michael Lockwood, *Māmallapuram and the Pallavas* (Madras: Christian Literature Society, 1982), 6–12; S. Markel, "An Iconographical Assessment of the Great Relief at Māmallapuram," master's essay, University of Michigan, 1980; and M. Lutzker, "A Reinterpretation of the Relief Panel at Māmallapuram," in *Chhavi 2: Rai Krishnadasa Felicitation Volume* (Banaras: Bharat Kala Bhavan, 1981), 113–18. For a summary of early sources on the debate, see W. Willetts, *An Illustrated Annotated Annual Bibliography of Mahabalipuram on the Coromandel Coast of India: 1582–1962* (Kuala Lumpur: Department of Indian Studies, University of Malaya, 1966).
3. Lockwood, *Māmallapuram*, 6, considers the possibility of what he calls punning in this relief but rejects it because the evidence for Arjuna's Penance seems weak to him. Susan Huntington, *The Art of Ancient India* (New York: Weatherhill, 1985), 303–4, raises in a footnote the possibility of intentional ambiguity and calls for "further substantiation" of that idea. I am indebted to Joanna Williams for introducing me to issues surrounding this relief, particularly to the possibility of its intentional double meaning.
4. See Mikhail Bakhtin, *Rabelais and His World* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1984) and T. Todorov, *Mikhail Bakhtin: The Dialogic Principle*, trans. W. Godzich (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1984). Many thanks to Matt Leone of Colgate University for carefully reading a draft of this article and for helpfully explaining Mikhail Bakhtin's theories about dialogism, heteroglossia, and other ways of analyzing the voices articulated in works of art.
5. See, for example, Desai's application of Mircea Eliade's term *intentional language* to the practice of encoding multiple meanings into an image: D. Desai, "Placement and Significance of Erotic Sculptures at Khajuraho," in *Discourses on Śiva*, ed. M. Meister (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1984), 152. Chu-ting Li finds deliberate ambiguity in Chao Meng-fu's "Sheep and Goat" handscroll: "The Freer *Sheep and Goat* and Chao Meng-fu's Horse Paintings," *Artibus Asiae* 30, 4 (1968): 279–346. B. Rojzman, "Bible Reading: The Hermeneutic Narrative," in *Uses of Adversity*, ed. E. Spolsky (Lewisburg: Bucknell University Press, 1990), 105–6, finds that Biblical narrative contains ambiguities deliberately constructed to play upon differences in meanings, noting that in such reading environments new possibilities of reading will always remain open. Katherine P. Ewing, *Sharī'at and Ambiguity in South Asian Islam* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1988), argues that Muslim community members "value and exploit" ambiguity (which she calls at one point "pragmatic indeterminacy") in order to obscure differences among segments of the community.
6. Both Lutzker, "Reinterpretation," and M. Hirsh, "Royal Implications of the Unique Subject Matter, Scale and Format in the Narrative Reliefs at Māmallapuram," *Bulletin of South Asian Religious Art Studies* 3 (October 1983): 56–63, and "Mahendravarman I," see this relief as an expression of the king's protective function, but both use that argument to limit their reading of the relief to a single narrative. Lutzker argues against Arjuna's Penance. Hirsh resists the Descent interpretation.
7. The view has since been obstructed by a museum, the later Talaśayana Perumāḷ temple, and the eighth-century Shore Temple. Little evidence has emerged, however, to support the hypothesis that the buildings of Māmallapuram originally extended considerably to the east. For a rebuttal of the theory that much of the ancient city has been submerged by the Bay of Bengal, see Willetts, *Bibliography*, 2.
8. By contrast, see a Ganeśa image from northeastern Rajasthan, ca. 1000–50: Danielle Mason, "New Perspectives on the Temple Sculptures of Northern India," *Orientations* 24, 7 (July 1993): fig. 11.
9. Vidya Dehejia, "On Modes of Visual Narration in Early Buddhist Art," *Art Bulletin* 72 (1990): 388–92, finds a similar mode of narration, which she labels a "narrative network," in mural painting at Ajanṭā.

As the Ajaṇṭā murals are located in common halls between monks' dwelling cells, the complexity of this narrative mode seems to have relied upon viewers' deep familiarity with the subject matter. See also C. Pinney, "The Iconology of Hindu Oleographs: Linear and Mythic Narrative in Popular Indian Art," *Res* 22 (Autumn 1992): 33–61, on the interlace of optical paths laid out in Indian visual narratives.

10. The preceding summary is derived from *The Mahābhārata*, trans. and ed. J. A. B. van Buitenen (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1975), vol. 2, 3 (31) 39–41, pp. 298–303; and *The Kīratārjunīyam by Bhāravi*, trans. K. C. Kaisher Bahadur (Kathmandu: Ratna Pustak Bhandar, 1972), 189–218; Arjuna's Penance is narrated in canto 12. For further discussion of the *Mahābhārata* passages, see Lutzker, "Reinterpretation," 114–16. On the popularity of Bhāravi's poem at court, see Huntington, *Art of Ancient India*, 642 n. 16.
11. Ramachandran, "Kīratārjunīyam," 70–71, takes this gesture to mean that Śiva is revealing a secret to Arjuna (that Arjuna is linked to the sage Nara because both are forms of Viṣṇu) and pointing below to a representation of Nara, the figure seated to the left of the small shrine. These would, however, be very unusual meanings for *varada mudrā* to sustain.
12. Perhaps designers of this relief also intended viewers to read, as some of my students have, the triangular shape above the ascetic as one of the boulders Arjuna hurled at Śiva during their dispute over the boar. It seems at least as likely, however, that this segment of rock was outlined in order to be removed. Similar indentations form grids on several other sections of this cliff, as if sections of rock were outlined prior to being chipped away.
13. T. A. Gopinatha Rao, *Elements of Hindu Iconography*, 2nd ed. (Varanasi: Indological Book House, 1971–), vol. 2, pt. 1, 216–17.
14. On this as the standard iconography for this subject, see Rao, *Hindu Iconography*, vol. 2, pt. 1, 216.
15. I refer to the people who conceived and executed this relief by the term *designers* in order to encompass artisans, workshop directors, intellectuals, even kings themselves—anyone who may have contributed to these designs. The process by which decisions were made in the creation of Indian works of art remains a topic of much discussion. Recent evidence suggests that artisans may have had some choice in the iconographic details of what they rendered and perhaps in details of composition as well. See J. Williams, "From the Fifth to the Twentieth Century and Back," *Art Journal* 49, 4 (Winter 1990): 363–69; and B. N. Goswamy, "Pahari Painting: Family as the Basis of Painting Style," *Mārg* 21 (1968): 17–62. For other studies on traditional modes of artistic production in India, see *Making Things in South Asia: The Role of Artist and Craftsman*, ed. Michael Meister, Proceedings of the South Asia Seminar 4 (1984–86) (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1988).
16. Dehejia, "Modes of Visual Narration," 382–84, observes similar condensations in early Buddhist sculpture and classifies them as the "synoptic mode" of narrative.
17. Lockwood, *Māmallapuram*, 7, brought to my attention this relief, which is in shrine 16 of the small alcoves lining the interior of the precinct wall. This is the only other Pallava illustration he has found of this narrative. The panel on the north side of the Shore Temple's enclosure wall, mentioned by Ramachandran, "Kīratārjunīyam," 87, as another example of Arjuna's Penance, is a later (eighth-century) reinterpretation of the large relief, however one reads the latter. Lutzker, "Reinterpretation," 115, describes other renderings of Arjuna's Penance in Rajasthan.
An anonymous reviewer of my essay has alerted me to the recent discovery of a large carved image of a boar recently excavated just north of the precinct of the Shore Temple in Māmallapuram. Walter Smith has been kind enough to share with me his slides of this piece. From these, however, I cannot discern any firm iconographic evidence that this represents the boar shot by Arjuna. Under the creature's belly curved forms seem to indicate teats, which would eliminate Varāha as the subject of this piece. I cannot read the coiled mass beneath the teats. If it comprises intestines, might they indicate the boar's slaughter? The boar stands, however, apparently alive.
18. These figures were first brought to my attention by Markel, "Iconographic Assessment," 11. Ramachandran, "Kīratārjunīyam," maintains that the Gaṅgā flowed beside Arjuna's camp; Lutzker, "Reinterpretation," 115, points out that the Gaṅgā is not mentioned in this light in either the *Kīratārjunīyam*'s or the *Mahābhārata*'s presentation of this narrative; but Michael Rabe, in personal communication, notes that both texts locate Arjuna's camp on the bank of the Ganges.
19. Summary derived from Vālmīki, *Rāmāyaṇa: Sanskrit Text and English Translation* (Gorakhpur, 1960),

- bk. 1: *Bāla-Kāṇḍa*, 133–37; and *The Mahābhārata*, van Buitenen, vol. 2, 3 (33) 107–8, 428–30.
20. On the possibility of a water system at Māmallapuram and a cistern above the cliff, see Huntington, *Art of Ancient India*, 304; Lockwood et al., *Mahabalipuram*, “Introduction,” n. 6; and Lutzker, “Reinterpretation,” 117, n. 24.
 21. “[H]osts of Rsis and Gandharvas as well as the inhabitants of the globe touched [sipped] the water fallen from the person of Lord Śiva . . . as purifying.” Vālmīki, *Rāmāyaṇa*, bk. 1: *Bāla-Kāṇḍa*, canto 42, ll. 23–29, 135.
 22. Lutzker, “Reinterpretation,” 116–17. Lutzker dismisses Ramachandran’s reading of this as Nara worshipping Kṛṣṇa (Nara was an earlier manifestation of Viṣṇu and thus a sort of precursor to Arjuna), noting that the iconography of the figure within the shrine points unambiguously to Viṣṇu.
 23. Lockwood, *Māmallapuram*, 10–11, lists eleven such sites. On the arrangement of figures, see Lockwood et al., *Mahabalipuram*, 35.
 24. See, for example, the Kaśākūḍi plates: *South Indian Inscriptions*, India Archaeological Survey (rpt. Delhi: Manager of Publications, 1983–84), vol. 2, pt. 3, 347, ll. 34–36; this is also the example cited by Lutzker, “Reinterpretation,” 113.
 25. Lutzker, “Reinterpretation,” 116, points out that only the *Rāmāyaṇa* describes Śiva catching Gaṅgā in his *hair*. Since the *Mahābhārata* does not, she argues, that could be the verbal correlate of this relief. However, the *Mahābhārata* describes Śiva catching Gaṅgā on his *brow*, and the large Māmallapuram relief does not illustrate that either. This verbal text, from a time and place quite distant from this relief, seems a less useful object of comparison than nearby, Pallava-period, visual representations of the same subject. For other Pallava Gaṅgādhara images, see n. 23 above.
 26. While the Kailāsanāth temple was built roughly a century after the Māmallapuram relief, the Trichy example precedes the Māmallapuram relief by as much time. Similar representations of Śiva Gaṅgādhara at Māmallapuram’s Ādi-Varāha temple and Dharmarāja Ratha (Lockwood, *Māmallapuram*, 10) are roughly contemporary with the large relief.
 27. Moreover, Markel, “Iconographical Assessment,” 7, points out that Śiva’s specific attributes are inappropriate for both narratives. Rao, *Hindu Iconography*, vol. 2, pt. 1, 216, 315–17, lists the deer, noose, lock of hair, *kataka mudrā*, *abhaya mudrā*, and touching Umā’s chin as suitable occupations for Śiva Gaṅgādhara’s four hands; Śiva as the hunter granting Arjuna’s request may hold the bow, deer, noose, or *bana*. In the Māmallapuram relief, Śiva holds the ax, trident, and *varada mudrā*. His upper right hand may once have held a deer.
 28. The *Kīratārjunīyam* also describes a host of *gandharvas* and *apsarāsas* visiting Arjuna to tempt him away from his austerities. *The Kīratārjunīyam by Bhāravi*, canto 10, pp. 109–45. This, however, does not address the presence of *kinaras*.
 29. For discussions of these interpretations, see Lutzker, “Reinterpretation,” 117–18; and Ramachandran, “Kīratārjunīyam,” 59–66.
 30. Williams was the first to bring to my attention the importance of this smaller relief to a reading of the larger relief. Ramachandran, “Kīratārjunīyam,” 86–88, and Longhurst, *Pallava Architecture*, pt. 2, 44–45, also saw this smaller version as a sort of rough draft for the larger relief, although Ramachandran maintained that this relief also depicted Arjuna’s Penance.
 31. Joanna Williams also understands the smaller relief to precede the larger in date of execution. See “Unfinished Images,” *India International Centre Quarterly* 13, 1 (March 1986): 96–97. To my knowledge the only published study of such a shift in Pallava sculptural style is Michael Dan Rabe, “The Monolithic Temples of the Pallava Dynasty: A Chronology,” 3 vols., Ph.D. diss., University of Minnesota, 1987. I have deduced this sequence from a study of sculpture on buildings to which rough dates can be assigned. Scholars have produced a relatively secure chronology for Pallava architecture. That chronology has persisted with only minor adjustments from Longhurst’s work to the recent chapters by K. R. Srinivasan in the *Encyclopaedia of Indian Temple Architecture*, ed. M. Meister (New Delhi: American Institute of Indian Studies, 1983–).
- Nagaswamy has challenged this chronology, proposing that the Pallava king Rājasiṃha (r. 700–28) commissioned all the monuments at Māmallapuram. See R. Nagaswamy, “New Light on Māmallapuram,” in *Silver Jubilee Volume*, the Archaeological Society of South India, 1960–62 (Madras: Archaeological Society of South India, 1962), 1–30. This intriguing article is ultimately unconvincing in large part because it fails to address style, which varies enormously at this site. In its place Nagaswamy offers a rather mechanistic analysis of motifs and poses, building his argument instead upon a discussion of terms used in stone

inscriptions. His thesis does not address the visual dimension of this art, nor can it. For further rebuttals, see Srinivasan, *Encyclopaedia*, 76–78; and Lockwood et al., *Mahabalipuram*, 62–86.

32. Cf. the image of Śiva Dancing in Śiyamaṅgalam: K. R. Srinivasan, *Cave-Temples of the Pallavas* (New Delhi: Archaeological Survey of India, 1964), pl. XXIII. An inscription verifies this as a project patronized by Mahendravarṇa I Pallava, whose rule spanned the first three decades of the seventh century: *Epigraphia Indica*, 6:319–20, as cited by Srinivasan, *Cave-Temples*, 91.
33. I consider this flattened quality a function of style rather than of the incomplete state of carving. The surfaces of these shallow images are essentially finished. Further work on this relief would more likely have focused upon removing the shelves of rock that still hang over some figures and upon smoothing the surfaces between figures.
34. Compare figures in Māmalla's Ādi-Varāha cave temple and in the upper tiers of the Dharmarāja Ratha, which can be assigned to Paramēśvara I. I argue the attributions of these monuments in Padma Kaimal, "Stone Portrait Sculpture at Pallava and Early Cōla Temples," Ph.D. diss., University of California, Berkeley, 1988, 70–73 and 100–102, respectively. For plates, see Srinivasan, *Cave-Temples*, pl. LIII–LVI; and K. R. Srinivasan, *The Dharmarāja Ratha and Its Sculptures* (New Delhi: Abhinava Publications, 1975).
35. Mahendra I is credited with the *Mattavilāsa* and the *Bhāgavadajjuka*. See L. S. Barnett, "Matta-vilāsa: A Farce by Mahendra-vikrama-vārman," *Bulletin of the School of Oriental Studies* 5, 4 (1930): 697–717; M. Lockwood and A. Vishnu Bhat, trans., *Mattavilāsa Prahāsana (The Farce of Drunken Sport)* (Madras: Christian Literature Society, 1981); C. C. Mehta, *Three Sanskrit Lighter Delights* (Baroda: University of Baroda, 1969); and M. Lockwood and A. Vishnu Bhat, trans., *Bhāgavadajjuka* (Madras: Christian Literature Society, 1978). On the popularity of the *Kīratārjunīyam* at the Pallava court, see n. 10 above.
36. The entire *Rāmacaritam of Sandhyākaranandin* reads simultaneously as a retelling of the *Rāmāyaṇa* and a history of the Pāla king Rāmapāladeva. See *Rāmacarita by Sandhyākara Nandi*, ed. Haraprasad Sastri, *Memoirs of the Asiatic Society of Bengal* 3, 1 (Calcutta: Asiatic Society, 1910). My thanks to an anonymous reviewer of this essay for suggesting this example. For another example of Sanskrit punning see a passage from the "Naiṣadhacarita" of Śrīharṣa in B. N. Goswamy, *Pahari Paintings of the Nala-Damayanti Theme* (New Delhi: National Museum, 1975), 16.
37. See n. 24 above.
38. See K. V. Soundara Rajan, "'Cult' in Pallava Temples," *Transactions of the Archaeological Society of South India* (Madras: Archaeological Society of South India, 1969), 143–62; and Lockwood et al., *Mahabalipuram*, 18–33.
39. This inscription was first published by E. Hultzsch in *South Indian Inscriptions*, vol. 1, nos. 33 and 34, but in the translation quoted here Lockwood, *Māmallapuram*, 62–73, alters Hultzsch's translation in several significant details. In particular, Lockwood proposes that Śiva's jealous consort is Gaṅgā rather than Parvatī.
40. Lockwood, *Māmallapuram*, 6–13, 76–79. Huntington, *Art of Ancient India*, 642, n. 18, also sees links between linguistic predilections and visual double meanings. She suggests that a relief image of an ascetic on the Vaikunta Perumāl temple in Kāñcīpuram may represent Aśvatthaman and Bhagīratha simultaneously.
41. See n. 40 above.
42. On the military aspect of the king's protective duties, see Burton Stein, *All the King's Mana: Papers on Medieval South Indian History* (Madras: New Era Publications, 1984), 3–11.
43. On the ritual dimension of the king's protective duties, see R. Inden, "Ritual, Authority and Cyclic Time in Hindu Kingship," in *Kingship and Authority in South Asia*, ed. J. F. Richards (Madison: University of Wisconsin Press, 1978), 28–73; and A. Appadurai, *Worship and Conflict under Colonial Rule: A South Indian Case* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1981).
44. Although to my knowledge no inscriptions have been found on the large relief itself, other inscriptions at this site name Pallava kings (and no other patrons) and frequently link them directly to the monuments. See Longhurst, *Pallava Architecture*. This situation contrasts sharply with that of the early Cola period, for example, in which most names mentioned in association with art patronage are not royal. See Kaimal, "Stone Portrait Sculpture," ch. 5.
45. My picture of the south Indian state derives largely from B. Stein, *Peasant State and Society in Medieval South India* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1980); and N. Dirks, *The Hollow Crown: Ethnohistory*

- of an Indian Kingdom* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1987).
46. Asher, for example, reads the Udayagiri relief of Varāha rescuing Earth as an "historical allegory" for Candra Gupta II uniting the Gupta empire. F. Asher, "Historical and Political Allegory in Gupta Art," in *Essays on Gupta Culture*, ed. B. Smith (Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass, 1983), 53–66. Asher defines allegory as "a story which serves as an analogy to a real-life person or event, usually making that person or event more vivid, poignant, or dramatic" (p. 54). J. Williams, *Art of Gupta India* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1982), 45–46, has a similar reading, noting that Candra Gupta II rescued his sister-in-law as Varāha rescues Earth. Huntington, *Art of Ancient India*, 298, finds a Pallava case of such allegory, reading references to King Māmalla's military victories in the Varāha cave's depictions of Varāha and Trivikrama triumphing over demonic forces. In the iconography of the Arjuna Ratha she suggests that royal and divine imagery overlap and that a single figure may signify three deities at once. S. Huntington, "Iconographic Reflections on the Arjuna Ratha," in *Kalādarśana*, ed. J. Williams (New Delhi: Oxford and IBH in collaboration with American Institute of Indian Studies, 1981), 60, 63. Huntington, *Art of Ancient India*, 303–4, also suggests that the theme of Arjuna's Penance in Māmallapuram alluded to Pallava conflicts with the early Western Cālukyas.
 47. Lutzker, "Reinterpretation," 113, and Hirsh, "Royal Implications," also read these lions as Pallava royal emblems but use that evidence to argue for reading the relief exclusively as either the Descent or Arjuna's Penance, respectively.
 48. Seventh-century audiences in Māmallapuram may well have been exposed to the ideas in these much older sculptures at least through later versions of the same imagery. The Aśokan motif of addorsed lions on capitals persisted at least through the first century C.E. and into central India (on a free-standing column before the *chaitya* hall at Karḷe and on a gateway leading to the circumambulatory path around Stūpa I at Sāñcī). Lions atop pillars flanking gateways also appear as far south as Amarāvaṭī in relief representations of *stūpas* between the first and third centuries C.E. See D. Barrett, *Sculptures from Amarāvaṭī in the British Museum* (London: British Museum, 1954), pl. I–IV. For illustrations of the lion capitals at Lauriyā Nandangarh and Sārnāth attributed to Aśoka Maurya's patronage, see Huntington, *Art of Ancient India*, figs. 4.4 and 4.5.
 49. For inscriptions describing Rājasimha in leonine terms, see *South Indian Inscriptions*, vol. 1, no. 24, v. 11; no. 25, v. 7, 13, 20, 52, 54; no. 27, v. 3. On the attribution of the Śaluvankuppam *yālī-maṇḍapam*, see Srinivasan, *Cave-Temples*, 182.
 50. A verbal narrative of these events exists in the *Srimad Bhagavata Mahapurāṇa*, Part II: Books 9 to 12, trans. C. L. Goswami, 2nd ed. (Gorakhpur, 1982), bk. 10, discourse 25, 1162–65.
 51. To the right or northern side of the Descent/Penance relief is a small free-standing carving of three monkeys. The largest monkey pores over a female, closely grooming the back of her head, while the female nurses a baby and strokes its back. These too seem to amplify the theme of protection, albeit in a comic vein, but they were not originally part of the sculptural ensemble with the large relief and the Kṛṣṇa relief. The monkey group was discovered near a separate Śiva temple in Māmallapuram and was moved by Lord Napier to its current location in 1871. On this move, see Willetts, *Bibliography*, 34.
 52. On a similar use of pairing in Indian sculpture, see D. Sanford, "Early Temples Bearing Rāmāyaṇa Relief Cycles in the Chōḷa Area: A Comparative Study," Ph.D. diss., Los Angeles, 1974.
 53. Huntington, *Art of Ancient India*, 296, sees the presence of water symbolism in Pallava art as a reference to the public reservoirs those kings constructed. Asher, "Allegory in Gupta Art," 64–66, sees these two reliefs as references to the king's control of water through the Māmallapuram canal system.
 54. Inden, "Ritual, Authority," 35–37, describes a ritual in which the king guaranteed the fertility of the earth by plowing it, a gesture symbolic of sexual insemination.
 55. This heroic mode of kingship seems to have predominated at least from Mahendra I until Pallavamalla (r. 731–96), if not later. See Stein, *King's Mana*.
 56. See n. 31 above on this debate among Nagaswamy, Srinivasan, and Lockwood.
 57. Such as the imprecatory verse carved by Parameśvara I on the floor of his grandfather's Ādi-Varāha cave. See Kaimal, "Stone Portrait Sculpture," 71–73.
 58. See Williams, "Unfinished Images," 90–105.
 59. In one version of the verbal text, he eats a rabbit

- and partridge rather than mice. *The Pañchatantra*, trans. Arthur W. Ryder (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1972), 318–21.
60. Mieke Bal mentions the cat segment of this relief as an example of a narrative aspect she describes as “focalization,” “the relationship between the ‘vision’, the agent that sees, and that which is seen.” M. Bal, *Narratology: Introduction to the Theory of Narrative*, trans. C. van Boheemen (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1985), 102–4. She bases this interpretation, however, on a line drawing (by Fransje van Zoest) of the relief that seriously misrepresents these figures. Locating in the drawing one mouse who falls over backward and another who raises one paw, Bal reads the mice as laughing with relief as they “realize they are safe.” She understands the cat to be comic because it has foolishly attempted to imitate Arjuna, “impressed by the beauty of absolute calm.” Bal seems unaware of the *Pañcatantra* tale, which accounts for the mice and the cat’s pose without involving Arjuna. Whether the cat sees Arjuna or whether it even exists in the same time and space as Arjuna’s narrative is debatable. Comparison with my figure 25 will indicate, furthermore, that in the actual relief no mouse falls backward and that the mouse with the raised paw has raised his other paw as well, joining them together in *añjali mudrā*, connoting respect rather than mirth.
 61. Bakhtin, *Rabelais*, 192 and chap. 3, cites the episode of Gargantua drowning a crowd in his urine as a parodic travesty of Christ’s miracle with the loaves of bread. Bakhtin cites a number of examples of inversion, in which Rabelais narrates the degradation of kings to clowns.
 62. Bakhtin, *Rabelais*, 188, 274.
 63. Bakhtin, *Rabelais*, chap. 2.
 64. Bakhtin, *Rabelais*, 133–34 and 188.
 65. See n. 35 above.
 66. See David Dean Shulman, *The King and the Clown in South Indian Myth and Poetry* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1985), 153.
 67. Spolsky, *Uses of Adversity*, 10, points out that texts thus premised on viewer incompetence are not unusual.
 68. Bakhtin, *Rabelais*, 188.
 69. “It is disheartening that scholars should continue to argue about [the subject of this relief]”: *The Indian Express*, Madras, 28 December 1974, as cited by Lockwood, *Māmāllapuram*, 8, n. 4.